

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management

Sovereign Infrastructure Investment Memorandum

The Manchester Ship Canal Automation & Inland Port Renaissance Programme

A Public–Private Partnership to Create Britain's Smart Inland Maritime Corridor

Transforming the Manchester Ship Canal into Europe's Most Advanced Inland
Freight Waterway

Executive Summary

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management (EVWM) proposes the establishment of the:

Manchester Inland Port Investment Partnership (MIPIP)

A long-term public-private partnership to modernise, automate and expand the **Manchester Ship Canal** and its associated inland port network.

The objective is to transform the canal from a traditional freight waterway into a **digitally managed, automated logistics corridor** linking the Port of Liverpool with Greater Manchester.

Rather than competing directly with major deep-water ports, the canal would specialise in:

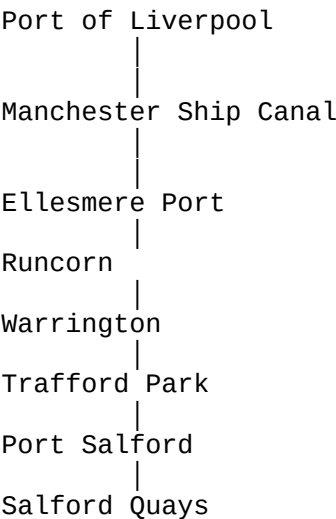
- inland container logistics
- automated barge transport
- construction materials
- low-carbon freight
- industrial supply chains
- advanced logistics technology

The proposal builds on existing investment in **Port Salford**, a tri-modal logistics hub with water, rail and road connections, and seeks to extend that concept across the entire canal system.

Strategic Vision

Britain's Inland Maritime Motorway

Future freight corridor:



The canal becomes a continuously managed freight corridor operating alongside the motorway and rail network.

Investment Programme

Total Programme

£1.8 billion

25-year PPP

Investor	Investment
EVWM Infrastructure Fund	£400 million
Pension Funds	£600 million
Private Infrastructure Investors	£400 million
UK Government & Combined Authorities	£400 million

Pillar One

Smart Canal Infrastructure

Investment

£400 million

Upgrade the canal through:

- digital lock control
- AI-assisted traffic management
- automated signalling
- remote bridge monitoring
- smart navigation beacons
- continuous water-level management

Modern vessel traffic management systems are already being developed internationally for autonomous shipping and inland navigation, providing a technological pathway for such upgrades.

Pillar Two

Automated Inland Freight Fleet

Investment

£300 million

Introduce a fleet of:

- electric container barges
- hybrid cargo vessels
- remotely supervised autonomous barges
- automated maintenance craft

Initially these would operate with onboard crews while progressively adopting higher levels of automation as regulations evolve.

Primary cargoes:

- containers
 - aggregates
 - steel
 - timber
 - construction products
 - recyclable materials
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Pillar Three

Port Salford Expansion

Investment

£450 million

Port Salford is already planned as Greater Manchester's first fully tri-modal freight terminal with direct rail, road and water access.

EVWM proposes accelerating development by adding:

- additional container berths
- automated stacking cranes
- robotic container handling
- AI warehouse management
- customs processing centre
- expanded rail freight sidings

Target:

A nationally significant inland logistics hub serving North West England.

Pillar Four

Trafford Park Inland Container Terminal

Investment

£250 million

Redevelop Trafford Park's canal frontage into a modern inland container terminal.

Facilities include:

- rail-connected freight yards
- urban consolidation centre
- automated warehousing
- cold-chain logistics
- customs clearance

Purpose:

Reduce heavy goods vehicle movements entering central Manchester.

Pillar Five

Canal Industrial Zones

Investment

£250 million

Encourage redevelopment of underused canal-side industrial land into:

- manufacturing parks
- distribution centres
- recycling facilities
- advanced engineering workshops
- modular construction factories

The Manchester Ship Canal remains the region's principal opportunity for expanding water-borne freight, and planning policy supports increased industrial use of canal-side land.

Pillar Six

Green Maritime Corridor

Investment

£150 million

Develop:

- shore power
- electric charging points
- hydrogen bunkering (where commercially viable)
- renewable-powered port operations
- battery storage systems

Objective:

Create one of Europe's lowest-carbon inland freight corridors.

Automation Strategy

Digital Canal Operations Centre

Create a central operations centre controlling:

- vessel scheduling
- lock sequencing
- bridge openings
- weather monitoring
- traffic optimisation
- predictive maintenance

Every commercial vessel would transmit live operational data, allowing the system to optimise movements and reduce delays.

Freight Capacity

Target sectors:

- retail distribution
- manufacturing
- food logistics
- building materials
- engineering products
- renewable energy equipment

Long-term objective:

A significant increase in water-borne freight, reducing pressure on the M62 and M56 corridors while improving supply-chain resilience. Regional planning policy specifically supports greater use of the canal for freight and identifies Port Salford as the key tri-modal hub.

Economic Impact

Construction

£1.8 billion programme

Estimated:

- 12,000 construction job-years
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Permanent Employment

Sector	Jobs
Port operations	2,000
Logistics	3,500
Manufacturing	2,500
Engineering	1,500
Technology	1,000
Total: approximately 10,500 long-term jobs	

Economic Benefits

The programme would support:

- improved freight resilience
- lower logistics costs
- increased industrial investment
- regeneration of canal-side brownfield sites
- expansion of manufacturing capacity
- growth of the North West logistics sector

Estimated additional annual regional Gross Value Added (GVA):

£600–900 million

Revenue Model

Income would be generated from:

- port handling charges
- canal access fees
- logistics leases
- warehouse rentals
- industrial property
- digital logistics services
- rail terminal operations

Target infrastructure return:

6–8% annually

Strategic Role

This investment complements other EVWM proposals by connecting:

- the expanded **Port of Bristol**
- the proposed **Cardiff Atlantic Gateway**
- the **Fleetwood–Barrow economic corridor**
- upgraded North West rail freight routes
- the Port of Liverpool

Together, these projects would strengthen Britain's western logistics network and improve connectivity between maritime trade, manufacturing and inland distribution.

Final Recommendation

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management recommends establishing the:

Manchester Inland Port Investment Partnership

A **£1.8 billion** PPP to modernise the Manchester Ship Canal into Britain's first digitally managed inland freight corridor.

The programme combines:

- smart infrastructure
- automated logistics
- modern inland shipping
- rail integration
- brownfield regeneration
- advanced manufacturing

Its central principle is straightforward:

The canal should no longer be viewed as a relic of Britain's industrial past, but as a strategic logistics asset for Britain's industrial future.